

MORE HARM THAN GOOD

We began to doubt the merit of charity work many years ago. A friend of ours had volunteered to go to Nicaragua during the Sandinista years. He felt guilty about the way the U.S. government had reacted to the communist takeover of the country. He wanted to help out by building houses.

So he went to Nicaragua at his own expense. There, he enlisted in a brigade of foreign volunteer workers. They toted blocks and laid bricks, without pay, helping to build shelter for the Nicaraguan population.

“You wouldn’t think a country like that would have a shortage of labor,” we suggested. “What’s the going rate for a day laborer down there?”

“Oh, it’s about \$2 a day.”

“Then, when you work a week down there, it’s the equivalent of a contribution of \$10.”

“Yes, I guess it is.”

“What do you earn in the United States?”

“About \$10 an hour.”

“Would they be better off if you worked in the United States for a week and sent them the \$400 you earned?”

“Well, I guess so. . . .”

“Forty times better off.”

“Yes, but they’d probably use the money to buy weapons—after all, the United States is supplying rebels who are trying to kill them.”

Yes, dear reader, life was not set up in a way that accommodates the fantasies of world improvers. Instead, it is almost impossible for them to do any good—except by coincidence.

Don’t believe us? Think someone who gives money to the Red Cross or Save the Whales or to fix the cleft palates of poor people *must* be doing good?

Not so. How does anything have value? Things don’t have value in and of themselves. They are given value by willing buyers and sellers. If no one wants a Hula-Hoop, it has no value. None. It has value only when someone has a want or a need for it. Otherwise, it is worth zilch.